Just Enough to Keep You Out of Jail

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This is not legal advice. We are not lawyers. This is the short list of things student teams actually trip over — the 20% that prevents 80% of the mess. When real money or real personal data starts flowing, buy one hour with a real lawyer (the startup legal office hours are free — book them).

1. Recording interviews

Ask BEFORE you hit record. Recordings may be spot-checked in class, so the question covers the course staff too. One sentence is enough:

> *"Dürfen wir das Gespräch aufnehmen? Es ist für unser Team und die Kursleitung, die Aufnahmen stichprobenartig prüfen kann." / "May we record this for our team and the course staff, who may spot-check it?"*

Get a yes on the recording. Store recordings privately (team drive, not public), share them only with your team and the course staff, delete if someone asks. Before raw notes, transcripts or recordings go into an AI tool or a shared read-out, take out names, contact details and anything else that identifies the person. That's it.

2. Your landing page

You're collecting emails in Germany. Three things, thirty minutes:

- **Impressum** — legally required on German websites, even test pages (§ 5 DDG, which replaced the TMG in May 2024). Use a generator (e.g. e-recht24), paste, done.
- **Privacy line** near the form: *"We store your email only to contact you about [product]. No sharing, unsubscribe anytime, contact: [email]."* If your form tool offers double opt-in, turn it on.
- **Don't** buy email lists, scrape addresses, or import your interviewees into a mailing tool without asking them.

Analytics: a cookieless EU tool such as Plausible needs no cookie banner (paid after a 30-day trial). Tools that set cookies, such as Microsoft Clarity (free) or Google Analytics, need a consent banner. Since 31 October 2025, Clarity sets no cookies for visitors from the EEA, the UK and Switzerland until your page passes their consent, and § 25 TDDDG asks for consent before anything non-essential is stored on a visitor's device. Read your per-source numbers knowing they count only visitors who accepted.

3. Taking money

Covered properly in Module 09. The survival version: an invoice needs 7 fields (both names & addresses, date, invoice number, description, amount, your §19 no-VAT note if you're under the Kleinunternehmer limits). A team taking money together with no setup is a **GbR — you are all personally liable**. Fine for pilots; revisit when real risk shows up.

4. The email list after the course

The consents you collected are for THIS product. If you kill the idea: delete the list. If you pivot: ask again ("we've changed direction — still want updates?"). Don't carry lists into your next project like furniture.

5. Other people's stuff

Don't paste competitor screenshots into your product, don't use unlicensed images/fonts on your landing page (use Unsplash/Pexels-style licensed sources), don't copy someone's pricing page word-for-word. Code from your own laptop is yours; code built on university lab infrastructure or in a paid job — check first (TUM ForTe / Venture Labs answer this for free).

When to actually get help

Any of these = book the (free) legal office hour BEFORE proceeding: handling health or financial data · customers demanding a signed contract you don't understand · first employee or intern · incorporation (UG/GmbH) · anyone threatening you with anything.

Checklist, not counsel.